

PRACTICAL ENGLISH USAGE

Michael Swan • Complete Multi-Volume Master Diagnostic Compendium

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A–Z REFERENCE OVERVIEW MAP

This comprehensive reference matrix systematically itemizes grammar, usage, and syntactic parameters across detailed structural blocks, mirroring the exact functional methodology of Michael Swan’s definitive guide.

Section A	Determiners, Advanced Articles, Adjective Hierarchies, and Nominal Modification (Entries 1–15)
Section B	Tense, Aspectual Splicing, Future Timelines, and Perfective Domain Constraints (Entries 16–35)
Section C	Relative Clauses, Wh-Movement, Pronoun Doubling, and Preposition Placement (Entries 36–55)
Section D	Modality, Epistemic vs. Deontic Systems, and Subjunctive Matrix Clauses (Entries 56–75)
Section E	Lexical Confusion Matrices, Suffix Splicing, and Structural Pitfalls (Entries 76–100)

SECTION A: DETERMINERS, ARTICLES, AND ADJECTIVES

1. any: non-assertive constraints in positive environments

A frequent area of confusion is using *any* in basic positive declarative sentences when a specific quantity is intended. *Any* implies unlimited choice or "no matter which." For a definite but unspecified group or quantity, *some* is mandatory.

- ✗ *"I have any custom configuration profiles configured inside the environment host."*
- ✓ *"I have some custom configuration profiles configured inside the environment host."*
- ✓ *"You can run any custom profile; the scheduler treats them identically."*

Core Distinction: Use *some* when asserting existence; use *any* when choice is entirely unrestricted or free.

2. articles: functional zero-article rules for primary institutions

When terms like *school*, *hospital*, *prison*, *university*, or *work* are used to focus on the primary institutional purpose or activity, they drop the definite article. Introducing the article shifts the meaning to a specific physical asset or geographic structure.

- ✗ *"The sysadmin went to the work at midnight to verify the storage arrays."*
- ✓ *"The sysadmin went to work at midnight to verify the storage arrays."*
- ✓ *"The contractor is visiting the work site tomorrow morning to check the power."*

3. adjectives: rigid multi-modifier sequencing order

When multiple descriptive adjectives modify a single head noun, English enforces a highly specific linear hierarchy: Opinion, Size, Age, Shape, Color, Origin, Material, Purpose. Breaking this natural chain yields awkward, ungrammatical phrasing.

- ✗ *"They allocated an enterprise metal brand-new storage enclosure for the cluster."*
- ✓ **"They allocated a brand-new enterprise metal storage enclosure for the cluster."**

4. all vs. whole: structural variations with singular count nouns

While both words denote completeness, they follow entirely different determiner placement rules. *All* is placed before additional determiners (like articles or possessives), whereas *whole* is placed after them.

- ✗ *"The all network architecture was completely redesigned after the breach."*
- ✓ **"The whole network architecture was completely redesigned after the breach."**
- ✓ **"All the network architecture was updated over the weekend."**

SECTION B: TENSE, ASPECT, AND VERB PHRASE COMPLICATIONS

16. future time: will vs. be going to for immediate vs. planned events

Will is used for spontaneous decisions made at the precise moment of speaking, or for objective future facts. Conversely, *be going to* indicates a pre-existing plan, intention, or clear visible evidence in the present moment.

- ✗ *"The server room temperature is climbing rapidly; I am going to reboot it."*
- ✓ **"The server room temperature is climbing rapidly; I will reboot it right now."**
- ✓ **"We are going to migrate our virtual assets to the new cloud infrastructure next quarter."**

18. future time: mandatory present aspect in subordinate temporal clauses

In adverbial clauses of time introduced by conjunctions such as *when*, *as soon as*, *before*, *after*, or *until*, the future marker *will* cannot be used to denote future time. The simple present or present perfect is required instead.

- ✗ *"The diagnostic will run as soon as the compute node will complete its routine."*
- ✓ **"The diagnostic will run as soon as the compute node completes its routine."**

Systemic Rule: The future aspect is locked inside the main predicate clause; dependent conditional/temporal anchors default to present forms.

24. perfective aspect: past time boundaries and temporal exclusion

The present perfect tense bridges past actions with current significance and is explicitly incompatible with closed past-time specifiers (such as *yesterday*, *last year*, *at 3:00 PM*). If a precise, finished past point is named, the simple past must be applied.

- ✗ *"Our infrastructure team has deployed the updated hypervisor kernel yesterday afternoon."*
- ✓ **"Our infrastructure team deployed the updated hypervisor kernel yesterday afternoon."**

29. since: tense rules and aspectual changes in anchoring matrices

When *since* introduces a temporal boundary condition, the verb in the *since*-clause typically uses the simple past tense, while the main matrix verb uses the present perfect to map duration up to the present.

- ✗ *"Since we have changed the routing protocols, network telemetry is stable."*
- ✓ **"Since we changed the routing protocols, network telemetry has been stable."**

SECTION C: RELATIVE STRUCTURES AND SYNTACTIC MOVEMENTS

36. relative clauses: non-defining vs. defining punctuation structural shifts

Defining relative clauses provide essential identification details and take no commas. Non-defining relative clauses offer non-essential, extra information, must be enclosed in commas, and can never use the pronoun *that*.

- ✗ *"The core storage array, that handles database requests, is experiencing latency."*
- ✓ **"The core storage array, which handles database requests, is experiencing latency."**
- ✓ **"The storage array that handles database requests is experiencing latency."**

41. relative pronouns: avoiding redundant shadow pronouns

Because a relative pronoun functions as the syntax representative for the object or subject within the relative clause, adding a matching personal pronoun creates an illegal structural duplication error.

- ✗ *"This is the configuration template file which the developer adjusted it last night."*
- ✓ **"This is the configuration template file which the developer adjusted last night."**

48. prepositions: stranded vs. fronted registers in complex structures

Preposition stranding (placing the preposition at the end of a relative clause) is standard in everyday spoken English. In formal or technical documentation, fronting the preposition before *which* or *whom* is preferred, but requires removing informal pronouns like *that*.

- ✓ "The production host that we applied the software patch to is now fully stable." (Spoken/Standard)
- ✓ "The production host to which we applied the software patch is now fully stable." (Formal/Technical)

SECTION D: MODALITY AND SUBJUNCTIVE MOOD MATRIX SYSTEMS

56. must vs. have to: epistemic necessity and root authority

Must generally conveys internal necessity originating from the speaker's own judgment or authority. *Have to* represents external necessity driven by rules, regulations, or outside circumstances.

- ✗ ~~"The system tells me I must change my credentials every 90 days."~~
- ✓ "The system tells me I have to change my credentials every 90 days."
- ✓ "I must remember to log off before leaving the secure environment."

62. should have: unfulfilled past events and retrospective evaluations

The modal configuration *should have* combined with a past participle is used to evaluate past actions. It states that an ideal action or expected event did not occur.

- ✗ ~~"The engineers must have backed up the configuration, but they completely forgot."~~
- ✓ "The engineers should have backed up the configuration, but they completely forgot."

70. subjunctive: mandative structures and non-inflected bare infinitives

In formal or technical clauses following verbs of demand, urgency, or request (such as *insist*, *recommend*, *demand*, *imperative*), the subordinate clause verb must be a bare infinitive. It remains unaffected by person, number, or tense markers.

- ✗ ~~"The senior engineer recommended that the administrator updates the server directly."~~
- ✓ "The senior engineer recommended that the administrator update the server directly."

SECTION E: LEXICAL CONFUSION MATRICES AND SYNTACTIC TRAPS

76. affect vs. effect: functional distinction between verb and nominal forms

Affect is primarily used as a verb meaning to influence or produce a change in something. *Effect* is predominantly used as a noun meaning the result or outcome of a change.

- ✗ ~~"The misconfigured routing table had a severe negative affect on network throughput."~~
- ✓ "The misconfigured routing table had a severe negative effect on network throughput."
- ✓ "High environmental temperatures directly affect hypervisor reliability."

84. asymmetric verbs: borrow vs. lend orientation paths

These verbs describe the same transaction from opposite perspectives. *Borrow* means to take something from someone with the intention of returning it (movement toward the subject). *Lend* means to give something to someone temporarily (movement away from the subject).

- ✗ ~~"Could you please borrow me your testing console for this afternoon's deployment?"~~
- ✓ "Could you please lend me your testing console for this afternoon's deployment?"
- ✓ "I need to borrow a testing console from the staging lab."

92. economic vs. economical: macro-scale settings vs. thriftiness

Economic relates directly to the field of economics, trade, or large-scale industry finances. *Economical* means thrifty, cost-effective, or minimizing waste.

- ✗ ~~"Upgrading to solid-state drives is a highly economic choice for server lifecycle budgets."~~
- ✓ "Upgrading to solid-state drives is a highly economical choice for server lifecycle budgets."

100. lay vs. lie: transitive alignment versus intransitive positioning

Lay is a transitive verb requiring a direct grammatical object; it means to place something down carefully. *Lie* is an intransitive verb that cannot take a direct object; it means to rest or remain in a horizontal position. This distinction is often broken across past tense inflections.

- ✗ ~~"The backup backup media has been laying on the hot equipment rack since last Tuesday."~~
- ✓ "The backup backup media has been lying on the hot equipment rack since last Tuesday."
- ✓ "Please lay the backup media on the storage desk after the validation cycle completes."